Board 1

South Deals

None Vul

	♠ Q 10 7 ♥ K 3 ♦ 8 7 4 3 ♣ A J 6 5	
♠ 6 4 ♥ 9 7 6 4 ♦ Q 9 5 ♣ Q 10 8 4	N W E S	♠ K 5 3 2 ♥ A Q J 10 ♦ J 10 ♣ 7 3 2
	♠ A J 9 8 ♥ 8 5 2 ♦ A K 6 2 ♣ K 9	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♣4, you play dummy's ♣5 and East plays the ♣7.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=3 Total = 6

You'd really like to find 3 winners without broaching that ♥ suit, so you decide to pin your hopes on the ♠ finesse. But you have a problem. When you win the first trick with the ♣9 your only safe entry to dummy is by leading your ♣K to the ♣A. And this uses up one of your ♣ winners! Do you see a way to avoid the problem?

Don't win the first trick with the ♣9, win with the ♣K. Then at trick two enter dummy by playing your ♣9 and finessing the ♣J! You are pretty sure West has led from the ♣Q so you expect this to work. Then play the ♠10, underplaying your ♠8. You had better cash the ♣A next, then the ♠Q, letting it ride if not covered. Finally, one last ♠ finesse gives you 4 ♠ winners.

This is another twist on the them of winning with a higher card than necessary.

Here it doesn't actually create an extra entry, it just preserves the one entry you have but saves you an actual trick.

Here is an interesting point. Suppose that West's opening lead had been a ♥ and East had taken the first four ♥ tricks then played a ♦. You would have played the hand the same way! Take the ♣K, then finesse the ♣J.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	North	
	♠ 4 ♥ K Q J 10 3 ♦ 10 6 4 ♣ 8 7 6 4	
West ♠ Q J 10 9 7 2 ♥ 9 7 4 ♦ 8 ♣ K 9 3	N W E S	**East** ♠ 8 5 3 ♥ 8 6 5 2 ♦ Q 9 7 ♣ A 10 5
	♠ A K 6 ♥ A ♦ A K J 5 3 2 ♣ Q J 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2♣
Pass	2♦	Pass	3♦
Pass	3♥	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♠Q.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=2 ♣=0 Total = 5

There they are, four perfectly good ♥ tricks and no straightforward way to reach them. On the other hand, (I should say "In the other hand"), you have the possibility of 6 ♦ tricks, if the ♦Q drops, in which case you won't need the ♥ tricks at all. Can you work those two possibilities into a strategy?

Sure. The ♦ problem is that the outstanding ♦s may split 3-1 with one defender holding ♦ Q x x. So it would appear you could only get 5 ♦ winners. But you can thwart him like this.

Win the ♠. Unblock the ♥A. Now play the ♦J. If Mr. ♦ Q x x takes this trick dummy's ♦10 will become an entry to those wonderful ♥s. But if he cleverly refuses to win the ♦Q, then it will fall under your ♦ A K and you will get all 6 ♦ tricks.

The biggest problem with this great play is that East probably doesn't know for sure what you are doing to him.

Maybe after the hand is over he will appreciate it more and congratulate you.

Board 5
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ K ♥ A K 7 5 3 ♦ A K Q 6 ♣ K 10 5	
♠ 8 7 5 4 ♥ 10 8 ♦ J 9 7 2 ♣ Q 8 4	N W E S	♠ A 6 2 ♥ Q J 9 4 ♦ 10 3 ♣ 9 7 6 2
	♠ Q J 10 9 3 ♥ 6 2 ♦ 8 5 4 ♣ A J 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2♣	Pass	2♠
Pass	3♥	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♦2.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=3 ♣=2 Total = 8

The reason the Winners list shows 1 ♠ is that the defenders are going to have to let you win dummy's ♠K. If they take that then you'll have 4 ♠ winners in your hand!

So you only need one more winner really, and if you guess the ♣ finesse right you will have it. Which way will you finesse, and why?

You will finesse through East. If he has the ♣Q you will win all 3 ♣ tricks, but if West has the ♣Q you may win even more. Just watch.

Win the opening ♦ lead in dummy. Play the ♠K which the defenders are not about to take while you have a ♣ entry to your hand. Now play the ♣10 and pass it to West. If West takes the ♣Q then you will have TWO entries to your hand, one to get there for a ♠ lead, and the other to reach the ♠ winners after you have driven out the ♠A. But if West DOESN'T take the ♣Q, or if East actually has it, then you will have 3 ♣ tricks and your contract.

Isn't it nice to have a finesse that wins if it wins but also wins if it loses?